



ESSENTIAL APPS GUIDE | LAST CHECKED AUGUST 2026

The apps you actually need in Shanghai

A short, practical setup guide for payments, messaging, navigation, public transport and translation - without downloading more than you need.

SAVE THIS BEFORE YOU FLY

START HERE

If you only download five apps

01 | COMMUNICATION

WeChat 微信

China's default communication tool for messages, contacts, groups, schools, landlords and mini programs.

English

Set up before flying

02 | PAYMENTS

Alipay 支付宝

The easiest all-round newcomer app for payments, transport QR codes and city-service mini apps.

English

Foreign cards

03 | NAVIGATION

Amap 高德地图

Start here for Chinese addresses, compounds, walking routes and metro journeys. Most newcomers only need one map app.

English

Our pick

04 | TRANSPORT

SH MaaS 随申行

Shanghai's official all-in-one transport app for metro, buses, ferries, QR codes and passes.

Foreign cards

Shanghai

05 | TRANSLATION

Pleco + a China-accessible translator

Use Pleco for dictionary lookups and keep a photo/voice translator ready. Google Translate is a backup, not a plan.

Set up before flying

Offline ready

Shanghai Connect pick: Use Amap to plan the route. Use SH MaaS to ride it.

SETUP TIMELINE

What to install, and when

BEFORE YOU FLY

Get set up

- WeChat + Alipay
- Amap
- Translation tools
- Connectivity / VPN

ONCE YOU LAND

Get moving

- SH MaaS
- DiDi, if you want it

ONCE YOU KNOW YOUR ADDRESS

Get fed

- Meituan
- Taobao Flash Shopping

ONCE YOU'RE SETTLED

Get comfortable

- Taobao
- Dianping
- Trip.com / 12306

BEFORE YOU FLY

Five things that save hassle later

01 Set up payments

Verify Alipay and WeChat and add a supported international bank card.

02 Sort out connectivity

Arrange any connectivity tools you rely on before entering mainland China.

03 Download translation tools

Keep offline dictionary or translation data wherever possible.

04 Save addresses in Chinese

Keep Chinese text and screenshots for your hotel, home, workplace or school.

05 Use a stable phone number

Verification gets messy if important accounts use a number you later lose.

QUICK RULES

Use both WeChat + Alipay. Start with Amap.

Save key addresses in Chinese. Add the rest only when you need them.

